



Top star: World No. 13 Romanian Bernadette Szocs was the highest-ranked player in the league followed by Nigeria's Quadri Aruna (20). R. RAVINDRAN

winner.

Although a top-10 player in the draft always makes for a good show, one has to understand that for a league to accommodate stars of such stature, more cash has to be pumped in. In fact, save the inaugural season in 2017, the league has failed to attract a single top-10 player for the draft. After all, there are no ranking points that a player stands to gain from the UTT. Plus, most players would have opted for a break with the Paris 2024 Summer Games having only concluded recently.

A sense of identity

The curious case of the missing audience may also be traced back to a majority of fans not identifying themselves with a particular franchise. The reasons are layered.

Having adopted a draft structure to acquire players, the UTT allows the retention of only one player going

into the next season. There is no scope for the retention of either the foreign or the Indian coach.

This dynamicity only translates into a major conundrum with every stakeholder — the management, players, fans and journalists alike — struggling to remember the threads a particular player would sport at the beginning of every season. There was even a prominent Indian player who, when asked during the dying stages of the tournament about her most memorable match from the ongoing season, had to be reminded which side Suthasini Sawettabut belonged to!

Developing a core group

The title-winning captain of the Athlead Goa Challengers, Harmeet Desai, concurs that more retentions are the way forward. He said, "We (himself and coach Zoltan Batorfi) were discussing it. I think it will help because sometimes it takes time for the player to understand the coach and vice versa. In the first two matches, it took time (to gel with the others), but if there is a 'coach retention' and more players are retained for the next edition, then the bonding would be much better.

We have become like family."

Portuguese coach Francisco Santos, who helped carry the Ahmedabad SG Pipers to the semifinal in its debut season, stares at an uncertain future despite the roaring success. "If I can stay, it will be a pleasure. But I understand the limitations of the format. Even if I end up finding myself in another side, I will continue with the same passion, motivation and goals. I have high hopes of coming back, though," he said.

Dire need for replacements

Another concern, which gathered steam as the league progressed, was whether the increase in the number of teams this season, up to eight from the earlier six, has diluted the intensity of the event. With a limited pool to pick players from, shoring up the bench to help with substitutions was an area found wanting.

For the lack of viable options, moments ahead of the title-deciding clash, Dabang's Diya Chitale sustained an ankle injury while limbering up. Despite the provision to have an injury replacement up to 10 minutes prior to the match, Dabang coach Vesna Ojstersek